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From the editor-in-chief

There's an old saying that money is the mother's milk of politics. In the Indian context, it's more a question of milking the state. We have reached a level of cohabitation where money, corruption and unethical deal-making occupy the same bed. Increasingly, people are joining politics to make money or stay out of jail. Money power is the dominant factor in today's electoral politics. Back in the mid-70s when INDIA TODAY was launched, I remember meeting politicians who were struggling to make ends meet. When we featured them next, they had become overnight millionaires. The point is not that we can't have wealthy politicians but the question of how they earned their wealth. I am sure there are many legitimately rich politicians but politics increasingly resembles a profitable business rather than a public service today.

It wasn't always so. Money power has played a positive role in politics: Industrialist G.D. Birla bankrolled Gandhi's campaigns and along with other businessmen entered politics inspired by the freedom movement. It was in the late '60s, when 'Aya Ram Gaya Ram' entered the political vocabulary, that money became a major factor. Since then the situation has only worsened with the dawn of coalition governments in the late '80s. With the likelihood of not being returned for the next term, they make hay while the sun shines and quite blatantly. No wonder many of these governments have been termed as 'cash and carry' ones. These days, it's almost impossible to find a poor politician except among the Left parties. Adding to the scenario is the fact that a large number of businessmen have joined politics in recent years, either elected or nominated by various parties.

So who are India's richest politicians? Thanks to a Supreme Court ruling in 2002, the filing of assets data is mandatory by anyone contesting an election. In order to establish exactly who are India's rich politicians, we undertook a study along with EmpoweringIndia.org, an initiative of the Liberty Institute led by Barun Mitra. It took three months of exhaustive research at the Election Commission and Rajya Sabha Secretariat by staffers Shyamlal Yadav and Sangram K. Parhi under the supervision of Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar to list the richest politicians whose submissions are open to debate.

The filing of assets data is mandatory but not verified. Some legislators have shown an increase in wealth of over 500 per cent in four years. Yet, the statistics are revealing. Of the 215 Rajya Sabha members for which we have data, 105 are crorepatas. Of the 522 Lok Sabha members, 135 are crorepatas. Members of legislative assemblies seem wealthier than many of the MPs. The top five MLAs across the 30 states are worth Rs 2,042 crore. Uttar Pradesh has the richest chief minister and 113 crorepati MLAs. One indication of how this money has been accumulated is that of 150 wealthiest MLAs, 59 don't even have a PAN card! Our cover story looks at India's richest politicians across various categories. A handful are legitimate businessmen, the rest only serve to reinforce the dubious nexus between power and money.



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COVER

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)